

- 📖 Hedges, Christopher. *War Is A Force That Gives Us Meaning*. Anchor, 2003. Hedges, a former New York Times war correspondent, draws upon his experiences in Kosovo and other war zones to explore the intoxicating psychic appeal of war — including a sense of moral clarity and a powerful national unity of purpose.
- 📖 King, Jr., Martin Luther. *Strength to Love*. Fortress Press, 1986. A fantastic collection of Martin Luther King's sermons on peace, nonviolence, love, and hope. Check out Dr. King's other books as well, *Trumpet of Conscience* and *Why We Can't Wait* are outstanding.
- 📖 Kinzer, Stephen. *Overthrow: America's Century of Regime Change from Hawaii to Iraq*. Times Books, 2006. A provocative history of 14 US-led coups, revolutions, and invasions that have toppled foreign governments, including Iran, South Vietnam, Chile, and Iraq. Kinzer uncovers US political and economic motives and analyzes the unintended long-term consequences for each regime change.
- 📖 Power, Samantha. *A Problem From Hell: America and the Age of Genocide*. HarperPerennial, 2003. Power, the executive director of Harvard's Carr Center for Human Rights, writes a thoroughly researched and powerfully written account of 20th-century acts of genocide and the US's often anemic responses.

FOUNDATION #3: ECOLOGICAL SUSTAINABILITY

A world committed to ecological sustainability would create a new vision of progress that recognizes that the future of humanity depends upon our ability to live in harmony and balance with our natural world.

CHALLENGES

Resource Overconsumption — Pollution — Global Warming — Overpopulation

Resource Overconsumption

Historically unprecedented levels of resource consumption are impacting every corner of the globe, permanently extinguishing unique species and threatening much of the biodiversity upon which all life depends. A 2000 report by the World Resources Institute found that increasing demands for natural resources are causing a rapid decline in many of the world's ecosystems.⁷⁶ The Living Planet Index, which measures the trends in wild species, found that from 1970 to 2000 land and marine populations dropped by 30% while populations of freshwater species decreased by a whopping 50%.⁷⁷

We have cut or otherwise destroyed nearly 80% of the world's ancient forests.⁷⁸ World demand for paper and lumber along with local demand for firewood is causing

developing nations to lose 6% of their forests every decade.⁷⁹ The results are increased global warming, species extinction, and loss of potential medicines. Natural forests contain about 50% of all life forms on the planet—with tropical forests containing the most biodiversity.⁸⁰ Many consider that we are causing an “extinction crisis” as we are causing species extinction at approximately 1000 times the natural rate.⁸¹

Unsustainable resource use threatens our way of life. Overfishing of ocean fisheries has created widespread alarm around the world. Globally, 75% of marine fisheries are being fished at or beyond their sustainable capacity.⁸² The quest for hefty profits rather than sustainable fishing has created a shortage that now threatens the entire industry’s ability to feed the world’s population. In addition, many countries, including the US, China, and India, overpump of their aquifers to irrigate their grain harvest. Falling water tables indicate that many aquifers will run dry in the near future—causing declines in food production.⁸³ Many experts also agree that the era of cheap oil is coming to an end.⁸⁴

The vast majority of the demand for natural resources comes from the rich industrialized nations of the world — especially the United States. This is no surprise, since the US lifestyle demands 120 pounds (54 kilograms) of natural resources per person per day.⁸⁵ The average American consumes as much energy as:

- 2 Germans
- 5 Mexicans
- 9 Chinese
- 15 Indians
- 54 Bangladeshi.⁸⁶

Since 1940, Americans alone have used up as large a share of the Earth’s mineral resources as all previous humans put together.⁸⁷ In fact, it would require four additional Earths to support the human race if all people on the planet lived the extremely wasteful lifestyles of North Americans.⁸⁸

Pollution

Have you ever noticed a brown cloud hanging over big cities? Or inhaled the crisp, clean air when you camp in a remote wilderness area? Unfortunately, air pollution is more than just a smelly annoyance; it kills about 70,000 Americans each year (more people than die from breast and prostate cancers combined)⁸⁹ and an estimated 3 million deaths worldwide every year.⁹⁰ Air quality is especially dangerous in rapidly industrializing countries such as China and India. Twelve of the fifteen cities with the worst air quality are in Asia (including Beijing, Jakarta, New Delhi, Shanghai, and Calcutta).⁹¹ The main causes of air pollution are energy production (especially from coal), industrial processes, and transportation.⁹²

According to the World Commission on Water, more than half of the world’s major rivers are “seriously depleted and polluted, degrading and poisoning the surrounding ecosystems, threatening the health and livelihood of people

who depend on them.”⁹³ Our oceans also bear our toxic burden. The US Justice Department found a fleet-wide conspiracy within Royal Caribbean cruise lines to save millions of dollars in disposal fees by covering up the dumping of oily waste into the ocean off of Puerto Rico.⁹⁴

Global Warming

According to the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change, the earth’s average temperature will increase between 2.5-10.4 degrees Fahrenheit (1.4-5.8 degrees Celsius) during this century.⁹⁵ Global warming threatens our future. Even modest warming could significantly impact agricultural yields, habitat integrity and vulnerable coastal populations around the globe. Even a one or two degree variation in temperature could shrink the grain harvest in major food-producing regions.⁹⁶

Emissions of greenhouse gases from burning of fossil fuels, especially coal and oil, have substantially contributed to global warming.⁹⁷ The US is the biggest culprit — emitting more than twice as much carbon dioxide (the primary global warming gas) per capita as the average rich industrialized nation (U.K., Japan, Germany).⁹⁸ Contributing to the problem, US federal automobile fuel efficiency standards have not been raised since 1985 — that’s over 20 years ago!⁹⁹ Even as the oil and automobile industries are admitting that precautionary action is warranted to halt global warming, the US and Australia (the world’s largest per capita emitters of greenhouse gases) have refused to join the 160 nations that have publicly committed to emission reductions.

Overpopulation

In October of 1999, the world’s population surpassed 6 billion people, doubling its size since 1960. In 2005, the human population grew by over 205,000 people per day or 75 million per year.¹⁰⁰ The United Nations projects that the world’s population will increase to over 9 billion by 2050—a 50% increase from 1999 — with the entire 3 billion added to the developing world.¹⁰¹ We might like to think that overpopulation is India’s and Africa’s problem, not ours, but when population strains lead to deforestation, global warming, war, malnutrition, starvation, and epidemics, the problem becomes a global one.

Overpopulation is a complex issue with a multitude of causes. The majority of women in the developing world wants to control their fertility but currently doesn’t have access to birth control options. Amazingly, the US exacerbates this problem by refusing to pay its share of the United Nations Population Fund, the primary international family planning resource. Poverty, coupled with limited educational and occupational opportunities for women, further exacerbate rapid population growth. As the developing world increasingly adopts a consumer lifestyle, the potential for ecological damage greatly multiplies.

GOALS

Clean Energy Sources — Sustainable Resource Use — Stable Population Growth — Global Cooperation

Clean Energy Sources

One of the most important changes we can make is to shift from fossil fuels to our most powerful and abundant natural resources: sun, wind and hydrogen. We already have environmentally sound, energy-efficient technologies to harness these renewable energy sources — we just need to use them. In 1997, the United Nations sponsored a global climate conference in Kyoto, Japan emphasizing the seriousness of global warming. The meetings produced a commitment from over 160 countries to significantly reduce greenhouse emissions by 2012 (the US was not among them). As a consequence, the demand for non-polluting energy sources is increasing worldwide, and the costs of using these technologies is steadily declining. Local US leaders have not let the feet-dragging of the federal government keep them from taking action. The mayors of “146 cities in 36 states, representing over 10 percent of the US population, pledged to enforce Kyoto’s US targets in their own cities.”¹⁰² At the same time, sales of hybrid electric vehicles in the US have exploded from fewer than 10,000 in 2000 to over 200,000 in 2005.¹⁰³

Renewable energy is not some naïve idealistic dream. It is technologically sound, affordable and spreading around the globe today. Global production of wind energy increased ninefold from 1995-2004 and continues to grow at almost 30% per year.¹⁰⁴ Global sales of photovoltaic solar cells (these are the ones that generate electricity from your rooftop) increased by 57% in 2004 and ten-fold over the past 10 years.¹⁰⁵

Creative, inspiring uses of “green” energy abound. Iceland has launched pioneering efforts to harness geothermal and hydropower to produce hydrogen for use in cars and boats.¹⁰⁶ In the Spring of 1999, Santa Monica became the first major city to meet its municipal energy needs entirely with non-polluting energy (geothermal).¹⁰⁷ In 2001, San Francisco voters overwhelmingly approved a landmark \$100 million initiative that pays for solar panels, energy efficiency and wind turbines for public facilities. And get this: the money is paid back through energy savings — at no cost to taxpayers!¹⁰⁸

Sustainable Resource Use

If we are to live in balance with our surrounding environment, we must learn from the principles of nature. The concept of waste, for example, does not exist in the forest. A fallen tree becomes a home for animals and insects, and helps to fertilize the soil for surrounding plant life. We must also learn to “close the loop” and use resources wisely. In order to combat pollution, Germany, Sweden, Spain, the U.K., and other countries are adopting “green” taxes — they lower income taxes and tax energy use,

thereby encouraging energy efficiency and investments in wind and solar power.¹⁰⁹ Many activists, consumers, and governments around the world are also holding industry to a higher standard of resource efficiency.

Encouraging examples of this kind of conservation ethic are happening all over the world. The world's largest producer of commercial floor coverings (Interface, Inc.) is on the cutting edge of environmentally sustainable businesses. They have implemented the principle of producer responsibility by using fewer materials, creating 100% recyclable carpets, and implementing customer leases that make Interface responsible for reclaiming the floor covering.¹¹⁰ Many European Union countries already have "Extended Producer Responsibility" programs whereby product manufacturers are required to take responsibility for the environmental impacts of their products. Car manufacturers must reuse or recycle 85% of the materials used to make their vehicles.¹¹¹

The creation of an economy where goods are produced, used, and remade into new products in the most environmentally responsible manner is a challenge that must involve every sector of our society — businesses, all levels of government, and citizens from around the world. Governments must stop subsidizing environmentally destructive industries, such as logging and oil, with corporate tax breaks. Switching from a pesticide- and fertilizer-based agricultural system to sustainable, organic farming will maintain soil integrity and preserve our health. Relying more on tree plantations and sustainable aquaculture will relieve pressure to cut down old-growth forests and overfish our oceans.

Fortunately, many people are already stepping up to the challenge. Twenty-six communities in New Zealand are pioneering a national Zero Waste pilot program to significantly reduce the amount of materials headed for the landfill.¹¹² Canberra, Australia and Toronto, Canada have even aimed to eliminate waste completely by 2010.¹¹³ Even consider this book. It is made of 100% post-consumer recycled paper, meaning that not one tree was cut down to produce it.

Stable Population Growth

Annual world population growth hit its peak in 1989 at 87 million people (that's births minus deaths). Since then, many industrialized countries have stabilized their populations, while developing countries still struggle with massive population growth. Wealthier nations must provide developing nations with the resources they need to curb their ballooning populations. These efforts need to be focused on improving the status of women, increasing access to family planning services, and bringing economic opportunity to poverty-stricken rural areas.

There have already been some amazing successes around the globe. Bangladesh, the most densely populated country in the world, has actually decreased its fertility rate from approximately 6.4 to 3.4 children per woman. Much of the decline is attributed to the regular use of contraceptives by 45% of

Bangladeshis in 1996, up from less than 8% in 1975.¹¹⁴ Empowerment of women is essential to stabilizing population. In Brazil, literate women average only two children while illiterate women average more than six children.¹¹⁵

Global Ecological Cooperation

To effectively address the challenges of climate change, resource depletion, and the breakdown of ecosystems, the nations of the world must act collectively and cooperatively. One only needs to look at the ozone layer to see the great potential of concerted global action. Scientists during the 1980s discovered a “hole” in a protective layer of the upper atmosphere. Based on their research, the Montreal Protocol, signed in 1990, phased out the production of ozone-damaging chemicals, such as chlorofluorocarbons (CFCs). This regulation slowed down the growth of the hole and eventually reversed the trend. Scientists now predict that the hole will be repaired by 2050.¹¹⁶

We must remember that public action can turn the tide and give us hope for the future. Public pressure for more stringent environmental regulation has led to technological progress that has significantly improved automotive and industrial emissions. Air quality in most of the developed world has been improving for the last thirty years because of this pressure.¹¹⁷ The foundations for a new “eco-society” are being built everyday with each hybrid-electric vehicle, wind turbine, recycling center and roof topped with solar panels.

➡ RESOURCES

-  Brown, Lester. *Plan B 2.0: Rescuing A Planet Under Stress And A Civilization In Trouble*. W.W. Norton, 2006. Written by one of the great environmental thinkers of all time, this award-winning book provides a readable analysis of our greatest social and environmental challenges. It details global problems and presents a realistic plan of action for ending poverty and nourishing our natural systems.
-  Brower, Michael, and The Union of Concerned Scientists. *Consumer's Guide to Effective Environmental Choices*. Three Rivers Press, 1999. A well-researched book that evaluates which of our actions make the most impact on the environment (and which ones you shouldn't worry too much about).
-  Hawken, Paul, Amory Lovins, and R. Hunter Lovins. *Natural Capitalism: Creating the Next Industrial Revolution*. Back Bay Books, 2000. The authors strike an unusual middle ground between capitalism and environmentalism. They use a number of current examples to illustrate a trend toward more eco-friendly, better technologies and more practical, sustainably-run businesses.
-  McDonough, William and Michael Braungart. *Cradle to Cradle: Remaking the Way We Make Things*. North Point Press. 2002. True sustainability can be

achieved only by thinking way outside the box — cars that actually clean the air, edible grocery bags, and 100% recyclable books. The book itself is printed on a polymer (rather than paper) that can be cleaned, melted and re-formed into a completely new book.

📖 Ryan, John C. and Alan Thein Durning. *Stuff: The Secret Lives Of Everyday Things*. Northwest Environment Watch, 1997. This fascinating, concise book traces the environmental impacts of everyday objects including a cup of coffee, a pair of sneakers, an aluminum can and a hamburger.

📖 The World Watch Institute. *State of the World* and *Vital Signs: The Environmental Trends That Are Shaping Our Future*. W.W. Norton. Annual publications. Provides up-to-date research on pressing global environmental problems, their causes, and their potential solutions. Great resources for assessing environmental trends.

FOUNDATION #4: DEEP DEMOCRACY

A world built on deep democracy would empower citizens to participate in shaping their futures every day (not just on election day), provide broad access to quality information, and democratize our most powerful institutions.

CHALLENGES

Lack of Democracy — Money in Politics — Media Control

Lack of Democracy

In 1989, 100,000 Chinese students and workers marched peacefully to protest government corruption in Tiananmen Square. Millions around the globe witnessed the Chinese government's violent crackdown that killed hundreds and injured additional thousands. Scenes of government repression and corruption happen around the globe every year. When the “bullet” triumphs over the “ballot box,” the hope of future generations for prosperity and freedom is stolen.

A government is democratic to the extent that average people have the ability to influence decisions that affect their daily lives and the future of their society. Unfortunately, dictatorships of military or wealthy elites rule much of the world without the consent of the people. Government of, by, and for these elites has created tremendous suffering for the average person. Unaccountable leaders in the developing world have often squandered their countries' wealth while leaving their people deeply indebted to international institutions.

Here in the US, we like to think that we're immune to rule by the few, when in fact, despite our historically groundbreaking beginnings, we are slowly moving back to that kind of government. Over the last 100 years, voter turnout has steadily declined. In 1996, for the first time in US history, less than 50% of the voting age population came out to the polls for the presidential election. In